

Cuban Pork & Mojo

6 lb bone-in · marinade → roast → pan reduction → pressed Cubano

CUT	MARINADE	OVEN	PULL AT	COOK EST.
6 lb bone-in	24–48 hr	275°F	195°F	~6–8 hr

PART 1

MARINADE

No salt — salt the meat (see cook)

Badia Mojo Marinade (base — garlic + onion already in it)	1,170 g	Onion sliced thin	1 large
Olive oil or lard (held — floats in a bath)	120 g	Cracked black pepper	12 g
Ground cumin (fresh — scale down if mild)	20 g	Bay leaves	5
Dried Mexican oregano	10 g	Maggi seasoning (umami — optional, rec.)	56 g
		Salt (NOT in marinade — salt the meat)	—

BLOOM

Non-negotiable — fat carries aromatics into the meat

- 1 Warm oil/lard over **medium-low** — not smoking.
- 2 Add **ground cumin**. Stir **30–45 sec** until nutty and fragrant. It burns fast — kill heat the second it's aromatic.
- 3 Off heat, add oregano, pepper, bay. Stir into residual heat **15–30 sec**. (no fresh garlic — Badia is already garlic-heavy)
- 4 Cool **5 min** to warm, not hot.

COMBINE & MARINATE

- 5 **Non-reactive container** (glass, stainless, food-safe plastic — **never aluminum**): combine Badia, bloomed fat-aromatic mix, onion, Maggi. Whisk hard — it separates into fat/water phases, normal.
- 6 Butt into a **4qt Cambro**, pour over to **submerge** (~1.5L covers a 6 lb butt in this vessel). Fridge **24–48 hr**; one flip at 12 hr for the fat-line surface.
- 7 **6 lb: 24 hr sufficient, 48 hr max**. Don't exceed — surface protein denatures and goes mealy.

Why bloom is mandatory: fat is the carrier that drives cumin and oregano warmth *into* the meat. Skip it and aromatics sit on the surface and wash off.

Cook & Reduction

PART 2

COOK

Stainless pan only — never nonstick at these temps with acid

Oven, fat cap up, on a rack over a stainless pan	275°F
Salt the butt directly before roasting (marinade has none)	—
Marinade goes IN the pan , butt on the rack above — drippings fall in, onion cooks down	~1.5L
Top with water if the pan reduces low / threatens to scorch	—
Pull at internal	195°F
Rest, tented, before slicing	45–60 min
Total estimate (stall-dependent)	~6–8 hr

Foil by bark, not clock: roast **open** until the bark is **dry, deeply colored, firm** — **doesn't smear** (~few hours). THEN foil to protect it through the stall and finish. **Tent the edges** if they run ahead — burnt edges put bitter bits in the drippings, which become the sauce.

PART 3

PAN REDUCTION

The marinade reduced — this IS the finishing sauce

No separate mojo build — the bloomed aromatics rode the marinade into the pan and cooked down with the drippings. Pour **pan liquid + drippings** into a pot:

- 1 Hard rolling boil** first — mandatory, the marinade was raw-pork-contaminated. Not a gentle simmer.
- 2 Reduce to coats-the-spoon** (nappe), but keep **enough volume to hold the sliced pork**. Make extra; reduce less far if short. Taste for salt; cut with water/unsalted stock if it sharpens.
- 3 No finishing citrus** — reduced Badia carries plenty of acid. Optional squeeze of lime off-heat *only* if flat/dull (brightness, not sour).
- 4 Hold the sliced pork in the warm sauce** to drink it up before building — the step that makes it next-level. Make enough.

Body & tuning: won't reach nappe before salting out → **cornstarch slurry** (gentle simmer, don't hard-boil after — acid breaks it). Too acidic → pinch sugar or ~0.6g baking soda. Fat stays in — rounds the acid.

The Cubano

PART 4

BUILD

bottom → top

- 1 Cuban / soft sub roll, split
- 2 Yellow mustard, **both** inside faces
- 3 Swiss (bottom — acts as glue)
- 4 Roast pork (soaked in the warm reduction) + spoon extra sauce
- 5 Ham (slightly ruffled)
- 6 Dill pickle planks
- 7 Swiss (top)
- 8 Top bread; **butter both outside faces**

PRESS

Blackstone flat-top, IR-gun an even zone to **275–300°F**

Second griddle/pan on top as the weight — compress to $\frac{1}{3}$ **height**

Per side, cheese melted **and** bread shatter-crisp **~4–5 min**

Slice on the diagonal **serve hot**

275–300°F, not 400°F+: dual-target — bread crisps fast, cheese melts slow. Too hot = scorched crust, cold cheese. IR-gun the surface, find the even zone, re-check as it drifts.

Hold the slices: rest sliced pork in the warm reduction so it drinks the sauce up before building — this is the next-level step. Make enough sauce to actually submerge them.

KEY PRINCIPLES

v2 hard-won learnings — the "why"

Flood the pan WITH the built marinade	Reverses old advice: v1 failed because the marinade was pure acid. This one has a bloomed savory base — in the pan it catches drippings and reduces into the sauce. Top with water if it scorches.
One aromatic build, at the source	The bloomed cumin/oregano in the marinade carries through to the reduction — no second mojo build. The marinade onion cooks down in the pan for umami.
Reduced Badia carries the acid	No finishing citrus — the base is heavily acidic and concentrates. Optional squeeze only if the sauce tastes flat/dull, for brightness not sour.
Fat stays in the sauce	Buffers acid, carries flavor, correct for a pressed sandwich.
Stainless, never nonstick	At roasting temps/durations with acidic content, nonstick is out.